

(see Concept 23.3). Typically, gene flow occurs between the different populations of a species. This ongoing exchange of alleles tends to hold the populations together genetically. But as we'll explore in this chapter, a reduction or lack of gene flow can play a key role in the formation of new species.

Reproductive Isolation

Because biological species are defined in terms of reproductive compatibility, the formation of a new species hinges on **reproductive isolation**—the existence of biological

▼ **Figure 24.3 Exploring Reproductive Barriers**

